

Films of 1969



Rules: Oscar nominees in major categories were watched. BAFTA and Golden Globes nominees were usually watched as well. A 1969 US release was usually stuck to concerning eligibility. A few foreign language films were included, but only stand outs as well as available spaghetti westerns. Given that in 1969, the Hays Production Code ended and the first Rating System started, how many liberties the film took will factor in. Also during this time films started to be films on-location more, which will also be factored in.

Tier 11: Each of These Could Be the Worst Film Ever

92. **Camille 2000:** Roger Ebert had this film on his 'Most-Hated' list and deservedly so. The film is an awkward Swinging 60s soft-core that attempts to be artsy and have a plot, but only really accomplishes some of the artsy sequences. The dialogue is bland and somehow delivered in an even more bland fashion; there are better hard-core actors than the 'stars' of this film. The sex scenes are few and faaaar between, and laughably bad (one would think the director was Mormon given there is zero movement during the sex scenes—only soaking). At least some of the bad soft-core/'boundary-pushing' films from earlier years had the decency to be over in less than 90 minutes. Yet, at two hours and ten minutes the viewer ends up watching about two hours after they've lost interest. [Swinging 60s]
91. **All Monsters Attack:** You know how the best *Godzilla* films are not actually about Godzilla; the original being about nuclear weapons, *Minus One* being about the aftermath of World War II. Technically *All Monsters Attack* is not about Godzilla, but it is also — almost certainly — the worst film in the franchise. The film is 'about' a latchkey kid who is frequently bullied, and imagines being on Monster Island with Minilla (Godzilla's son), who comforts him and teaches him to stand up to bullies! (Minilla also has a bully kaiju to overcome). The actor playing the kid is awful, and multiple scenes feel like they are written for a bad episode of *Sesame Street*. The film reuses stock footage from multiple previous films in the franchise, and still only manages a seventy-minute runtime. The entire endeavor is awful. At least some of the bad films in the franchise were at least campy. This film is cheap, lazy, and bad. The only reason to watch is to complete the franchise. [Godzilla]

Tier 10: Avoid

90. **Le Gai Savoir (The Joy of Learning):** I have been handing out negative reviews for Jean-Luc Godard films (*Made in U.S.A* and *La Chinoise*) since I started the 60s (starting in 1966). In Godard's only defense, this misses his 'classics' (though *Week-End* is often lumped in with the classics, but I also was not too high on it). Yet this film finally takes the cake of awfulness. Some of the experimental elements are nice (why even with his previous films, they couldn't rank this low). Yet this film is so brazenly political and *wrong*, it has committed one of my cardinal sins of movie making. The film has the gall to blame starving children in Africa on capitalism (ironically capitalism will nearly wipe out global extreme poverty by the time I write this review in 2024), all while praising Mao Zedong—who's famine is estimated to have killed 15–55 million Chinese. At this point, I feel safe in saying that Godard's films are loved by collegiate film minors who tweeted out #FreePalestine, while not voting in 2024. The sooner we stop pretending Godard is a good director, the better. [Godard]
89. **Hell's Belles:** A generic outlaw biker film from American International Pictures. Directory Maury Dexter (*The Mini-Skirt Mob* and *She-Devils on Wheels*) adds a flourish or two and makes nice use of the Arizona wilderness. Yet the plot is forgettable, the dialogue near-atrocious, and the acting often pathetic. The cast includes standard AIP players from previous biker films, none of which really stand out. [Outlaw Biker Gang]
88. **Blood of Dracula's Castle:** A B-movie that brings little to the table. The only nice shot is on the tower at the now-closed Marineland of the Pacific. The older cast could have carried deeper and funkier development. John Carradine (*The Astro-Zombies*) continues being solid in B-movies at the end of his career. Alexander D'Arcy is suave and a flamboyant as Dracula (similar to a Gomez Addams character) and could have made the character quite campy if given more room to shine. But there is still too much padding of the brief runtime, night-time killer character that adds little to plot. And no scares with few shocking moments. [B-movie Dracula]
87. **Satan's Sadists:** One of the more interesting outlaw biker gang films. It is also one that could of had something really going for it. The dialogue is still atrocious, the acting is not very good (a better gang leader would have improved the film greatly; Russ Tamblyn who had an Oscar nomination and would go on to be in *Twin Peaks* didn't capture the crazy properly). Al Adamson does add some nice touches (the acid scene being decent), but the film still suffers from too much b-roll of bikes to pad the runtime. The contrast of the bike gang and the fresh-outta-Vietnam Marine is nice. The Marine character is reminiscent of the *Billy Jack* character, and has some nice depth (for it being a B-movie). [Outlaw Biker Gang]

Tier 9: Bad Art House, Middling B-Movies, and Flops

86. **Charro!:** The only Elvis film where Elvis does not sing on-camera (he sings the opening credits; it is a decent song). The two issues in this western are that Elvis is not a good actor (it is easier hide in whimsy rom-com musicals). The plot itself is semi-standard but also nonsensical; Elvis' character tries to go straight from his former gang (who have stolen an celebratory and decorated canon—spoiler: the gang then uses said valuable canon to fire upon a town). Some people might like the actual change-of-pace from Elvis, but that still doesn't make the film good. [Elvis]
85. **Impasse:** Not even a young Burt Reynolds can save this film. Reynolds is given little to work with and doesn't even provide much charm (he'll be on the list again in a not-good film, but he's charming in that one). The plot itself is overly complicated and convoluted, with a few needless detours. The only redeeming quality is the on-location filming in the Philippines. Yet everything else about the film is forgettable. [Burt Reynolds]
84. **Otley:** A non-funny Bond parody. The film attempts to have a know-nothing fall ass backwards into the world of espionage, and succeeds out of sheer luck. Some of the bits are funny, but most are not,

and an unfunny comedy is one of the hardest things to sit thru. The plot itself is overly convoluted (if it is a comedy, keep it simple!), but keeping the plot simple would have reduced the 90-minute runtime down to forty (or the film needed a gag about how complicated things had gotten with an funny explainer for the audience). Watching all of these bad Bond parodies from the last few years, really makes one appreciate *Austin Powers*. [Bond Parody]

83. **The Cycle Savages:** An Echo Park-based outlaw biker gang film, which ranks here for one reason: Bruce Dern (*The Wild Angels*). Dern is the only one in the film who can really act, and he rides circles around all the other players. He does not phone in the performance (of what is obviously a B-movie). Dern makes the film watchable and elevates it. The film could have made better use of artist character who escaped the Soviet Union, as that back-story is ripe for development but nothing is done with it. The film proceeds about as one would expect, but watch for Bruce Dern. [Outlaw Biker Gang]
82. **The Oblong Box:** An American B-horror that attempts to mimic the Hammer Gothic horror films (and also attempts to be a poor mishmash of them, result in a sprawling plot). One would think that with Vincent Price and Christopher Lee the film would rank higher, but neither are give much ability to shine. They are let down by a script that is not scary, kills that are bad (the knife cuts look awful). The film could have been better if it made Price's character more campy. The villain is kept under a red hood for most of the film (including moments where he is alone, which is silly) and the final reveal of the 'gruesome' face is not worth the ninety minutes it took to see it. The film is a string of disappointments. [Price and Lee in a Horror]
81. **The Trouble with Girls:** Another standard Elvis film. At least here some of the shots are actually outdoors. The plot itself is contrivance after contrivance but it at least tried something beyond the standard Elvis plot. The songs are not very good (and there are few of them). If anything the film is more notable for having the actors who were the original voices of Velma and Fred on *Scooby-Doo*. Vincent Price is also briefly in the film, but because the plot is haphazard, he makes an appearance fro two scenes and is then never heard from. A young John Carradine is also in the film. Dodger legend Duke Snider is also in the film. But again, none of these people matter as the film wasn't interested in a detailed plot or character development [Elvis]
80. **Change of Habit:** The final Elvis film! The only reason this film is tolerable is that Mary Tyler Moore makes a rare film appearance as the co-lead. Moore is one of the great actresses and her whimsy can elevate anything. The primary issue of the film (besides Elvis being Elvis), is that the film wants to address social issues: autism, discrimination, the role of the church, etc. But the inclusion almost always is forced (Elvis plays a doctor in the low-income neighborhood after all). That the films spends too much effort saying look-at-me-I-care, than actually caring and developing these characters. [Elvis]
79. **Mackenna's Gold:** An absolute mess of film with a haphazard plot and the worst editing you'll ever see. The film starts with some nice aerial shots of the American West. It is then followed by on-location filming. Yet, almost every scene features mismatched cuts to the characters on a sound stage. I get having to do this once or twice in the movie as the film didn't come out right, so the re-shoot is quickly done on a sound stage, but these mismatched edits occur in almost every scene. Why was it filmed on-location? Could the director not get a basic shot to work? About halfway a slew of famous actors show up for all of fifteen minutes: Eli Wallach (*The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly*), Lee J Cobb (*Coogan's Bluff*), Edward G Robinson (*Little Caesar*), and Anthony Quayle. Even if the editing was good, the plot would hamper the film from ranking any higher. Yet some of the action sequences look and sound cool; the film uses POV shots for chases, and such. Those look cool. But with a half-baked plot, and awful editing the film can't rank any higher. At least Gregory Peck and Omar Sharif (*Funny Girl*) got paid a lot. [Good Cast]

78. **El Puro (La taglia è tua... l'uomo l'ammazzo io):** Also known as *The Reward's Yours... The Man's Mine*, the film starts with an interesting premise and then wastes it. The titular El Puro is a washed-up alcoholic former gunslinger with a bounty on his head, played by Robert Woods (*My Name is Pecos*). Yet, the film never asks why he's become an alcoholic, or show how it affects his daily life (besides not being able to shoot straight). To make matters worse, Robert Woods is not good in the role. The gang after El Puro is also not developed; and it is implied two of the men are lovers! (they even kiss once). But none of those five are ever developed in the 108 minutes run time (there is also a 95ish minute version, and the additional scenes do not add much, if anything). The ending is a nice bow on the film, but because the film wastes its runtime, the impact is not there. [Spaghetti Western]
77. **Don't Drink the Water:** A Cold War comedy that ends up being short on laughs. The film itself is based on a play written by Woody Allen, and there are a few funny lines. But not enough of them. Jackie Gleason isn't given much opportunity to shine. Estelle Parsons (*Bonnie and Clyde*) is mainly wasted by repeating the same three cleaning-related jokes, while Michael Constantine is probably the best actor as the leading of the Vulgarian secret police. It is a film that should have been funnier and better. [Woody Allen]
76. **The Chairman:** A spy thriller, that is not thrilling. Gregory Peck is charming, but he can't carry this film that offers little to the audience. The only saving 'grace' of the film is that it is about China, which for the time is a rarity. And it even features a character playing the titular Chairman Mao. But there are not real stakes, no real action. The film is a dud that tries to make some social and political commentary but fails miserably at it. [Gregory Peck]
75. **Midas Run:** A crime thriller, that is not thrilling. The heist takes too long, the aftermath of the heist takes too long. Fred Astaire is semi-charming, but not charming enough to make up for a slow-developing plot. Both Cesar Romero (*Batman*) and Adolfo Celi (*Grand Prix*) should be good, but are given little to do. Richard Crenna (*Wait Until Dark*) and Anne Heywood (*The Fox*) have nice chemistry, but their 'sex' scene is old fashioned with some bad editing. Had the film figured out how to make the heist exciting it could have ranked a little higher. [Fred Astaire]
74. **The Damned (Götterdämmerung):** Although the film came out before *Cabaret*, when watching it – if you've seen *Cabaret* – all you want to do is be watching *Cabaret*. They both trace the rise of Nazism with some drag and singing in beer halls. Yet few of the moments in this film land. Instead the writers seemed more interested in shocking the audience than developing characters (the drag orgy, the implied sexual assault of a child, the incest, as a few of the examples). Each event seems less interested in arising naturally from character development. Especially with such a sprawling cast of characters, it becomes a chore to keep track of everything as the actions are not organic, and most of the shock value is more implied than explicit (there are movies on the list that actually push the boundaries). The most-evil character is queer-coded, yet the writer-director himself was famously gay, only making the choice more confusing. Some of Maurice Jarre's score is great, but that is limited to the sequences of the ironworks. There are also a lot of awkward rapid zoom-ins, zoom-outs, and pans—none of which add much besides worsening the visuals. The film is an ambitious miss. [Oscars - Best Original Screenplay Nominee]
73. **Fellini Satyricon:** A plotless film, that is more interested in shocking the viewer than anything else. Federico Fellini was nominated for Best Director, and if I want to be cruel, because critics couldn't admit to themselves the film was garbage but rather that it had to be an avant-garde exploration of [insert whatever theme you believe will earn you the most social capital]. The characters are not developed. Every action is an odd combination of recreating a painting and what will offend the viewer the most. But because the film was directed by Fellini, the transgressions are 'artful'. The film is a boring chore. [Oscars – Best Director Nominee]

72. **No Room to Die (Una lunga fila di croc):** Also known as *A Noose for Django*, the film has nothing to do with the original *Django*; director Sergio Garrone made a few Django knock-offs. There are far too many awkward POV shots and zooms. This Spaghetti Western starts to scrape the bottom of the barrel. The English dub is often quite bad. William Berger is a standard of the genre, but he is not very good in this film; he can not do menacing well enough to be convincing in his role. The rough plot of the bad guys smuggling Mexican workers across the border could have been ripe for political commentary, yet instead the film stays with silly shoot-outs (and impaling people with a shovel of all known not-sharp instruments). The film doesn't really work and it never gets going, but one character has a seven-barrel shotgun which is cool. [Spaghetti Western]
71. **100 Rifles:** A film that thinks the action is going 100mph, but is actually going 30. There is so much 'action' but it goes nowhere. New scenes and locations pop up because they leads are always on the 'run'. Yet all of these sequences both prolong the film and eliminate chances at characterization. The film has Jim Brown (*The Dirty Dozen*), Burt Reynolds (*Navajo Joe*), and Raquel Welch (*Fantastic Voyage*)! All three are good, Reynolds being the best, but they are given little to work with. Instead the film only offers one of the first interracial (implied) sex scenes with Brown and Welch's characters. Outside of that, there is little of value. [Great Cast]
70. **Krakatoa, East of Java:** Yes, Krakatoa is west of Java, but that is not the worst part of the film. The special effects were filmed before there was a finalized script, and the producer left halfway. These result in a jumbled mess of plot, with too many characters and and tonal shifts (an awkward 'strip tease' is accompanied with a song). Some of the effects are nice, but too often they are merely shots of a 'volcano' spewing rocks. One of the best effects is the (model) boat sailing thru a narrow passage during the eruption, except as a plot point it is silly as *sailing thru a narrow passage during a volcanic eruption* is about as dumb as it gets when you could simply go around the island. [Oscars – Best Visual Effects Nominee]
69. **Eye of the Cat:** A 'horror' film that is light on scares and also light on camp. A film about killer cats could work, but in this film it does not. The film starts off with lots of awful direction (needless split screens for example). Michael Sarrazin is not very good. The script often contains poor dialogue (it was written by the writer of *Psycho*(!)). The only redeeming qualities are that it is off-the-wall (come on, killer cats), as the plot is both too predictable and too opaque. [Horror]
68. **The Undefeated:** A why-can't-we-all-get-along Western led by John Wayne and Rock Hudson (oh the subtext with choosing those two leads). Except, it too often veers into begin apologist for the Confederacy. The Rebels want to create their own post-war commune in Mexico and Wayne's former-union horse rustlers need to save the day. Except the Rebels are presented as normal people, even early in the film a carpetbagger is negatively portrayed. Given the film came out shortly after the passing of the Civil Rights Act, it becomes easy to interpret the film as simply wanting to put the past behind us and move on (and forget the bad things the South did). It doesn't help that neither Wayne nor Hudson are particularly great. [John Wayne and Rock Hudson]
67. **The Magic Christian:** A black-comedy about social class and wealth, that is too often a collection of bits than a coherent film. There are some laughs, but even those are few and far between. Peter Sellers is decent, and Ringo Starr is Ringo Starr. Had the film expanded out the sequence 'aboard' the titular Magic Christian ship into being the whole film then it could have worked; the boat sequence is zany and builds in intensity and laughs. But it sadly lasts only 20-ish minutes and occurs an hour into the film. As the first hour is a parade of various cameos and bits that rarely land. Terry Southern's (*Dr. Strangelove*) script did not deliver the goods. [Peter Sellers]

Tier 8: Bad-to-Meh, with a Redeem Quality

66. **Battle of Britain:** The film has a who's-who of British Acting to bloat the cast, yet given the size of the cast, there is almost nothing in the way of character development. The film hops around from various officers involved in defending Britain (and the subsequent new star) in a way that the viewer has little clue what is going on or why these character matter. It takes talent to handle a large cast and director Guy Hamilton (*Goldfinger*) was not up to the task. The aerial shots are nice, but some of the effects are also cheap and lazy (the German planes flying in 'perfect' formation is the worst offender). And with nearly forty minutes of aerial shots, they get repetitive; the first two dogfights are cool, but the fifth is redundant. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film]
65. **The Valley of Gwangi:** There are roughly six reasons to watch this film: the six stop motion animated creatures in the film. Ray Harryhausen (*One Million Years BC*) did the animation and they effects look great. The on-location filming in Ciudad Encantada is nice (viewers may recognize it from the Spaghetti Westerns *The Mercenary* and *Johnny Hamlet*). Yet, the rest of the film is essentially a B-movie, and often proceeds as such. James Franciscus (*taking Jane Fonda's virginity*) is charming and had star-potential. While Gila Golan (*Our Man Flint*) was cast entirely for her looks. Enjoy the animation, but realize the rest of the film will be a slog. [Ray Harryhausen Animation]
64. **Frankenstein Must Be Destroyed:** Peter Cushing continues to be great as Dr. Frankenstein, and this is one of the better Hammer Horror films. The two best moments are at the start (a 'gruesome' beheading that looks good for 1969) and end (a house fire), which makes the middle bog down. The plot of this film does at least makes sense: Frankenstein wants to transfer the brain (of a now insane) fellow doctor into a healthy body, so that Frankenstein can get a secret formula needed to further his experiments. The supporting cast is decent especially Thorley Walters as the buffoonish inspector tasked with tracking down Frankenstein. It has the hallmarks of being a Hammer Horror film, but it rises above most of them. [Hammer Horror Film]
63. **Winning:** A melodramatic racing film that gets the racing wrong. Paul Newman's character drives in multiple series and types of cars (which happens, but not that successfully for most drivers). The Indy 500 features a large crash, but then the number of cars stays roughly the same (I believe they used real footage from multiple races). The editing of the racing is fast-paced but does not add to anything; cuts are made to tires, engines, etc without rhyme or reason. The melodrama itself is standard and is only tolerable because Paul Newman is a great actor. [Paul Newman]
62. **That Cold Day in the Park:** Robert Altman's first directorial effort, and sadly it is difficult to see much of his future trademarks. There are two scenes with nice overlapping dialogue (doctor's office and night club), but that is about it. Sandy Dennis (*Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*) is good, but the script lets her down. The script lets everyone down. The film had the potential to be a sexually-charged thriller/horror, but it meanders in the first hour before it gets going. It also does not help that Michael Burns was not up to the task as The Boy (also the script, in a poor attempt to build mystery, has his character be silent for the first thirty minutes). The film eventually figures out what it wants to say, but by time it does, too much time has passed and the viewer has lost interest because the character development did not add up. László Kovács has a few nicely frame shots and it is another feather in his cap as a quality cinematographer. [Robert Altman]
61. **The Arrangement:** Kirk Douglas, Deborah Kerr, and Faye Dunaway can not save a poor script by Elia Kazan, who also directed. The opening sequence is good, and one would hope sets the tone for the entire film, but sadly the film becomes a bland melodrama without character development. Douglas's character starts an affair with Dunaway's character, but almost nothing motivates their relationship (Dunaway tries to charm the affair into existence, but the character development does not allow for it; beyond the basic, 'I'm bored with life and my marriage'). The film then adds more 'layers' to the drama: a rocky relationship with a father, a child, a divorce, etc. It is never bad, but it is rarely good. Elia Kazan directed multiple classics in the early 50s, but time had passed him by. [Elia Kazan]

60. **More:** A decent film about the darker side of the Swinging-60s. The three main issues are: i) the dialogue is often stilted, ii) the male character tries heroin for the first time with about fifty minute left (resulting in the final portion of his downfall dragging out for too long), and iii) mediocre acting (Klaus Grünberg being the worst while Mimsy Farmer was cast for her looks she is at least able to provide a modicum of mystery to her character). The film is possibly best known for the fact that [The] Pink Floyd wrote the soundtrack (which wasn't that notable). Yet the overall drama, romance, and downfall for the most part work. [Swinging 60s]
59. **The Computer Wore Tennis Shoes:** A family-friendly Disney film that although suffers from a few predictable downs, remains enjoyable-enough. A young Kurt Russell stars and does a good-enough job (when he 'breaks down' he borders on overacts, but for a teenager it is acceptable). Cesar Romero (*Batman*) as the villain is delightful as he has some fun with the role. Joe Flynn is enjoyable as the bumbling Dean of the college. There are a few laughs, a wholesome message, and it rarely feels forced. Which means the film can rank here. [Disney]
58. **A Boy Named Charlie Brown:** In what could be one of my more contraversial rankings, this film isn't that good. The animation quality (outside of the *Fantasia*-inspired sequences) is extremely poor and basic. The script at times feels too much like a comic strip. Some of the songs are not good. At 85 minutes, the film still drags. Yet it is wholesome, with a few good jokes (some of which are aimed at adults). The overarching messages are well-beyond what are normally seen in children's films (especially at the time). But that doesn't mean I need to think it's great. Note: The film was released in NYC in December 1969, but was nominated at the Oscars honoring films from 1970 for some reason. [Oscars – Best Song Score Nominee]
57. **John and Mary:** A film with Dustin Hoffman (*The Graduate*) and Mia Farrow (*Rosemary's Baby*) with Peter Yates (*Bullitt*) directing should be so much better. Yet this film is mostly a dud. The premise of Hoffman and Farrow's characters getting to know each other after a one-night stand is a good premise (especially in 1969). Yet these characters are nearly one-dimensional and do not feel like adrift twenty-somethings in NYC. The film is mainly confined to a large loft apartment, but rarely makes innovative use of the small space. The voiceovers of the inner monologue of each character does not work (*Annie Hall* would eventually split this atom; the film itself could have benefited from being less of a drama and more of a rom-com). Although these characters allegedly slowly fall for each other over the course of the day, the audience never figures out why they would. The various flashbacks to previous relationships rarely works either. It is sad, as the potential for so much more was here. [Golden Globes – Best Screenplay Nominee]
56. **The Happy Ending:** A 'woman's' film about a housewife growing tired of her marriage; a sub-genre that when it works, works. Yet this entry does not offer much; partially as its tone is all over the place (some bits of comedy interposed with melodrama) and its faux-progressive nature; too many of the supporting characters still want to get married or stay married despite their sordid pasts. The non-linear plot of flashbacks showing the dissolution of the marriage, never provide the audience with much reason for why the characters fell apart (and started cheating, drinking, etc); likewise the initial relationship shown over the opening credits and then extending for ten more minutes doesn't work to show the magic of the relationship. Jean Simmons is good, but not great and therefore unable to elevate the film much, nor are the supporting actors standouts. It is a film caught between eras that never finds its mark. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee]
55. **The Bridge at Remagen:** A standard World War II film that adds little to genre. The action sequences are decent, but nothing special (those involving tanks do look cool, but that is often because the tanks are crushing stuff and they had a fair bit of them moving around). George Segal (*Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*) is decent as the 'lead', but the script gives his character little beyond weary-from-years-at-war. The same can be said about Robert Vaughn's (*Bullitt*) character—the opposing nazi commander of the titular bridge. The film wants to show the futility of war and

how war corrupts, but there are never enough moving moments. There are attempts, but they rarely land. The film is not a chore to watch as there are enough action sequences, but it frequently misses its mark. [World War 2 Film]

54. **If It's Tuesday, This Must be Belgium:** The film has some laughs, but not enough. And it has too many characters, that it is unable to accurately jump (dropping the pervert-photographer, and the kleptomaniac would improve the film a bit and drop the forced comedic relief). The film mainly works because Suzanne Pleshette (*The Bob Newhart Show*) is one of the all-time underrated actresses (she went toe-to-toe with Bob Newhart for years!). Ian McShane (*John Wick*) is charming but not quite up to the leading man. A few actors from *The Graduate* have supporting roles and are good in them. But the film doesn't come together as well as it could if it had been more focused on the better characters. [Golden Globe – Best Screenplay Nominee]
53. **Boot Hill (La collina degli stivali):** The third film in the trilogy of Terrance Hill and Bud Spencer spaghetti westerns all of which were directed by Giuseppe Colizzi (*God Forgives... I Don't* and *Ace High*). (A company should really get the rights to all three, and do a proper restoration.) Though out of all the three this film features the least of Hill and Spencer together (Spencer doesn't even show up til 30ish minutes in). Instead the real star of the film is Woody Strode (*The Professionals*) as the (gunslinger-turned) trapeze artist. Yes, trapeze; the film is far too interested in the circus and pads the runtime with shots of the circus (and uses so awkward edits; from a gun shot to a trapeze artist flying thru the air). Almost all of the circus scenes could be dropped. The social commentary is too upfront and center but it at least gives characters purpose and development. [Spaghetti Western]
52. **Hello, Dolly!:** A musical that was fifteen years old the moment it was released. The 1890 setting allows for some nice costumes, but that is about it. The songs are largely forgettable. The dance numbers are decent, but are too long (they mainly exist to show more costumes). The film is directed by Gene Kelly (*Singin' in the Rain*) and I assume he forgot that the main reason his extended dance numbers worked was because he is one of the most talented dancers on earth (and that he made his great films at least ten years earlier). Thankfully Barbra Streisand (*Funny Girl*) is a god, even if the script does not allow her character to fully shine. Walter Matthau (*The Odd Couple*) is good as always, even if he is not much of a singer. The surprise star is Michael Crawford (*A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum*) as his role helps hold the films sprawling plot together. The film is a miss, but with a few nice elements. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]

Tier 7: Mediocre and Mindless Entertainment

51. **Support Your Local Sheriff:** A comedy-western that relies more on the cast than the script for laughs. The script doesn't have enough jokes and multiple ones they have aren't that good or are lazy. James Garner (*Grand Prix*) is charming and sly as the newly appointing sheriff. Harry Morgan (*Frankie and Johnny*) is always enjoyable as the town's mayor. Bruce Dern is hilarious as the arrested outlaw. Then the film even got Walter Brennan to play his father! The cast is deep and they are all great. Yet, they are all let down by a middling script. [Great Cast]
50. **Right of Bright Water:** Sometimes you have a cute otter and need to make a movie about said otter. The film is standard family-fare, with a few oddities (who gets an otter from a pet store? what pet store carries an otter?) and a few plot holes (what happened to the geese?). The flaws are forgiven as the animals are adorable. It is well-made family fun, with a plot that isn't pure mindlessness. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film]
49. **Age of Consent:** Helen Mirren's first big role, and she is good (her character could be given more to work with, as Mirren's talent doesn't exactly shine thru, instead it only comes thru). James Mason (*Georgy Girl*) is also good as the older artist. Except every scene that isn't only Mirren and

Mason (and the dog) is almost a chore. As instead of developing characters, the film too often puts in needless ‘comic relief’ caricatures (the alcoholic grandmother and free-loading friend being the worst offenders). That takes time away from Mason and Mirren, and leaves their character slightly underdeveloped. The on-location filming at the Great Barrier Reef is nice. [Helen Mirren]

48. **Tell Them Willie Boy is Here:** An early attempt at a Western being semi-sympathetic to Indians, and the film is about one of the last posse-oriented manhunts in US history. The film does elicit some sympathy for Natives, and Robert Blake (being white, *going all OJ on his wife*) is the titular Willie, and is solid. The biggest is Katherine Ross (*The Graduate*) is Willie Boy’s girlfriend (?) and is in far too much make up (red-face?) to be a realistic native (and so the sympathies the film tries to elicit are thrown out the window). The film also never accurately conveys the relationship of Willie and Ross’s character; do they actually love each other? did he really kidnap her? (The manhunt starts after he shoots her father—he caught them together). Had the film developed that relationship the first hour-plus would be much better. The final twenty minutes is rather good, as the score becomes excellent and the suspense ratchets up. Robert Redford gets to do his Robert Redford routine of the reluctant sheriff who has a job to do, but is aware of the history of Indian mis-treatment. The film could be better, but Redford, Blake, and Ross make for a good trio. [Robert Redford]
47. **Tepepa:** Also know as *Blood and Guns*, the print I watched would randomly switch into Spanish or Italian instead of the English dub, which was a little annoying. Though the most annoying thing about this film is the runtime: two hours and eleven minutes. The film veers too much into the Mexican Revolution and therefore instead of being a brisk 100 minutes, adds an extra thirty minutes. Orson Wells (*The Immortal Story*) is decent, but is not given much screen time (one wishes Wells played the fat landowning villain or evil general in more Spaghetti Westerns). Tomas Milian is decent as the charming and comedic revolutionary (so his standard role). John Steiner (*Marat/Sade*) is good as the English doctor, and it is a role seldom seen in Spaghetti Westerns, making it a nice touch. Had the film trimmed its runtime by realizing the Mexican Revolution is a weak plot point, whereas the revenge and manhunt plots involving the three main characters is far superior, it could have ranked much higher. [Spaghetti Western]
46. **Marooned:** Part of watching this film is wishing you were watching *2001*, as the space scenes are vastly inferior. Yet the space scenes still look good for the day (instead of amazing regardless of the year watched); the miniatures are not as detailed and do not move as smoothly. The zero-gravity scenes are okay, but again pale in comparison to *2001* (again, it isn’t fair to compare an above-average film to one of the few contenders for greatest ever). The plot itself is a tad weak and has a few slow points. Gregory Peck (*Arabesque*) is always good and Gene Hackman (*Bonnie and Clyde*) outdoes the two other marooned astronauts. That the other two actors can’t keep up with Hackman is part of the problem given so much of the film is set in a three-person space capsule. It does make one nostalgic for space and American soft-power. As, a mild spoiler, the film launches a rocket from the eye of a hurricane, which is fun movie magic. [Oscars - Best Visual Effects]
45. **Death of a Gunfighter:** The is most infamous for its director, or lack thereof, as it is the first instance of Allen Smithee being credited as the director (a pseudonym used when directors wish to discredit their work). As lead actor Richard Widmark was essentially in charge and fired one director midway thru filming. And both ‘directors’ Robert Totten and Don Siegel (*Coogan’s Bluff*) combine to make a nice film; there are a few nicely framed shots. The script ultimately lets the film down as its sets up an end-of-the-west theme, but gets derailed. After Widmark’s character refuses to resign his post as Marshall, the town council instantly up and decides to... kill him. And that wild swing throws the movie off and it never recovers. It also doesn’t help that Widmark, being in control, almost certainly made his character out to be too good. If his character was shadier the themes would have come together a lot nicer. [Allen Smithee]

44. **Popi:** The film ranks here primarily based on the performance of Alan Arkin (*Wait Until Dark*). Arkin plays a Puerto Rican(!) father who is hustling to provide for his two young kids (both of the child actors do a great job). The film also captures the grittiness of 1960s New York City with some great on-location filming. Yet the plot goes off the rails, and the script is unable to pick a tone: there is some breaking of the fourth-wall, jokes during serious moments. Once the film moves to Miami, nothing makes sense anymore and the film loses its kitchen-sink drama feel and turns into more of a soap opera melodrama. [Golden Globes – Best Actor in a Drama Nominee]
43. **Stereo:** David Cronenberg’s first feature film. It is a little over an hour, and even then it drags.; the film was shot in black and white on a shoe-string budget and with no synchronous sound. All the sound is ‘scientific’ voiceovers about the participants in the telepathy study (who are shown on the film). The film never gets the voiceovers right (they are often too wordy and scientific; the ‘film’ itself is trying to be the footage of the study). Yet the overall idea of the participants dealing with telepathy and sorta forming an OG polycule is rather good. The setting of the University of Toronto Scarborough features gorgeous brutalist architecture, which the film makes full use of. Some of Cronenberg’s ideas are there, but from watching this film, one would not realize he was destined to be a star director. [David Cronenberg]
42. **The Secret of Santa Vittoria:** The film itself is a straightforward comedic tale of hiding wine from Nazis, with enough character development (and redemption) to ensure the film can move thru any lulls and unfunny parts. There are laughs, but not enough. More laughs might allow it to rank higher. Anthony Quinn (*The Shoes of the Fisherman*) is rather good as the bumbling Bombolini (and deserved his nomination). The film develops characters enough to offer a portrait of post-Mussolini Italy, but the film is not a dramatic tour de force, only that they put some effort into have characters. [Golden Globe – Best Actor in a Comedy Nominee]
41. **The 5-Man Army (Un esercito di 5 uomini):** I saw a 90ish minute version, while the original film is apparently closer to 105 minutes (the international cuts and re-cuts of Spaghetti Westerns always makes it difficult to track down ‘proper’ releases). So perhaps some of my criticisms are addressed in the longer cut. The film itself is a standard get-the-heist-gang together. The cast itself is rather good: Peter Graves, James Daly (*Planet of the Apes*), and Bud Spencer. The lengthy train-heist is the best part of the film, though it could have been done better (it never cuts to any of the soldiers in the train or the soldiers along the route; as part of the heist requires stealth and hiding the noise, but the audience is never shown if they are being stealthy). It also veers too much into Mexico Revolution, but that is familiar complaint I have for Zapata Spaghetti Westerns. [Spaghetti Western]
40. **The Reivers:** Adapted from one of the few William Faulkner novels I haven’t read. Yet, the best parts are almost certainly lifted directly from the novel (and same with the worst parts). The film has multiple voiceovers to convey the stream-of-consciousness from Faulkner’s novels. The voiceovers themselves do not fit with the film tonally, but the words themselves are incredibly lyrical (as to be expected from Faulkner). The first twenty-ish minutes is rough as it starts off as a standard *Disney*-style family-friendly coming-of-age film, but once the characters reach Memphis, it gets back into Faulkner’s bread-and-butter; showing that society’s outcasts are the good people in the world. The climax between the young boy, his father, and ‘Boss’ grandfather is well done and moving. The direction by Mark Rydell (*The Fox*) is nothing special and Steve McQueen isn’t that impressive either. I am not exactly sure why Rupert Crosse (*Ride in the Whirlwind*) got an Oscar nomination either. Most everything is good, but nothing great, yet there are still some flaws. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actor Nominee]
39. **Paint Your Wagon:** A comedy musical that functions better as comedy than a musical. Most of the songs are forgettable at best. Whereas some of the (subtle) jokes do land. Lee Marvin (*Point*

Blank) and Clint Eastwood carry the film and each of them are excellent. Marvin especially is able to do a lot of carrying (though one wonders how much of his character's drunkenness was acting). Although one knows where the film is going regarding Eastwood's and Seberg's characters, it is the getting there that is fun and progressive (even if the ending ends rather conservatively). The film is long at two hours and forty minutes, but it rarely drags as the duo of Marvin and Eastwood always find themselves new mischief to start. [Oscars – Best Score Nominee]

38. **if...:** The issue with the 'classic' is the film can not decide on a tone. Some scenes are shot in black-and-white (which apparently was due to lighting issues), but then multiple scenes are then shot in black-and-white with no rhyme or reason. Thematically it does not work. Some scenes are then surrealist (although they are not that surreal). Again there is no rhyme or reason for their inclusion. Thematically it does not work. The film wants to be a rebellious counterculture film, but it pales in comparison to the films coming out of the United States (perhaps the vibes in England were different). Malcolm McDowell is good and it is easy to see how it jump-started his career. Yet the film as a whole is a jumbled mess at times. Of note this film was released in England in 1968, but not in the US until 1969, so it is on the 1969 list. [BAFTA – Best Director Nominee]
37. **True Grit:** If John Wayne did not win Best Actor, the film is probably forgotten. It is not bad by any stretch, but its reputation relies on a popular actor winning a lifetime achievement award. Wayne is good in the film, and gets a few laughs, while showing Rooster Cogburn soften over time. Kim Darby is far better (if playing a fourteen year-old while she is closer to twenty-two) and the spunky and head-strong Mattie Ross. Glen Campbell on the other hand, should stick to singing country songs; when the best thing you do in the movie is sing the theme song, you have an acting problem. It has been a while, but I feel safe in saying the Coen Brothers remake was better. [Oscars – Best Actor Winner]
36. **Mississippi Mermaid (La Sirène du Mississippi):** Written and directed by François Truffaut, the film is a solid noir. Catherine Deneuve is rather good as the femme fatale. Yet her chemistry with the male lead is never quite there. She is attractive, but why he keeps being drawn to her is never conveyed and is therefore the major downfall of the film. The audience needs to believe he'd throw away his life for this woman, but the film never does so convincingly. Truffaut does ensure the plot isn't overly explanatory (but even then a few too many details are alluded to). Yet the script is still bold enough, and the on-location filming is wonderful. [Truffaut]

Tier 6: Well-Made Despite a Flaw (or Two)

35. **Play Dirty:** Often described as a British *Dirty Dozen*, that description does a disservice to both films. Michael Caine (*Alfie*) and Nigel Davenport (*A Man for All Seasons*) are both decent as the co-leads; Caine's character slowly becomes disillusioned with war, while Davenport's is already disillusioned. The plot falls apart in the last twenty minutes, due to a slight twist. At times the minor characters become a tad cliché, the inclusion of two gay characters is a tad iffy (this is suppose to be a ragtag group of criminals, but the couple are Arab and semi-sympathetic characters). [Michael Caine]
34. **The Italian Job:** Although the film itself is well-known, it isn't that good to be considered a classic. If anything, its status is a result of solidifying the plot of modern heist films. Michael Caine is delightful as the lead, and he gets a gang together to steal some gold. The other members of the gang do not have their characters developed (sans the computer 'hacker' who is into fat girls). The first two-thirds have a lot of jokes, but not all of them land. The climax of heist itself is done rather well and is a solid spectacle (the editing of it could have been better). The ending of the film is itself a bit of a cop out (and at risk of a mild spoiler), really puts the film in a historic context where the

‘bad’ guys can be the ‘heros’ of the film, but still not an idea that had been fully embraced. [Michael Caine]

33. **Twisted Nerve:** An early attempt at implying criminals might be genetically pre-disposed to commit crimes. Though sadly it does so in such a dated way (an attempted link to Downs Syndrome—then referred to as Mongolism). Hywel Bennett is rather good at playing both Martin and Georgie characters; the film functions better when the audience believes the Georgie character is purely manipulative rather than a genetic disorder (again; the film could have kept the genetic pre-disposition, but gone in a much better way). Hayley Mills (*The Trouble with Angels*) is equally good in a more adult role for her. The thrills are almost there and the film provides a new angle on the crime thriller. [BAFTA – Best Supporting Actress]
32. **Goodbye, Mr Chips:** I must first admit I did not watch the original 1939 version of the film before viewing this one. Given that WW2 features in the second half, I feel safe in saying there were some updates made. Perhaps the biggest update is that this film is a ‘musical’ though loosely one at that. Also almost all of the musical numbers could be dropped. Neither Peter O’Toole (*The Lion in the Winter*) nor Petula Clark (*Finian’s Rainbow*) crush their songs (in part because the songs are so forgettable). What O’Toole lacks in the singing department he more than makes up for in the acting department. He is absolutely amazing as the titular Mr Chips, deserved his Oscar Nomination and there is a strong argument he should have won the award. The second issue (besides the songs), is that the film is uneven. The first half, and even the first few sequences after the intermission take place over the course of a year. Then the remaining hour frequently jumps forward in time to show the evolution of Mr Chips, but the new motivations and development do not exactly match the pacing and characterization developed before the intermission. Most of the outdoor shots are nicely composed. [Oscar – Best Actor Nominee]
31. **Anne of the Thousand Days:** The film is possibly the best Anne Boleyn film. Although *A Man for All Seasons* came out a few years ago, that film was mainly propped up by more elaborate costumes and sets (and the boating scenes were nice). The script of *Anne* is wittier and does an excellent job with King Henry, it also helps that it is a role Richard Burton was born to play. Burton gives Henry required charm, wit, horniness, and rage. Geneviève Bujold is good as Anne, and partially what makes the film excel is that Anne is not presented as a victim of circumstance, but rather someone who played the game and lost. The production value of the film could have been improved (its seems some of the castle scenes were shot on sound stages). The film also does a decent job of showing the entirety of the Henry–Anne relationship, whereas other films rarely capture the full relationship. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]
30. **Topaz:** A mixed bag from late-career Alfred Hitchcock. The film slightly drags at times. The primary issue with the film is that the film is almost has two separate sections, with a dip in the middle. There is the classic MacGuffin (the titular Topaz), but the first half of the film focuses on getting information on the looming Cuban Missile Crisis. Whereas the second half is then focused on leaks within the French intelligence community. The film is rather cynical, filled with morally gray characters. There are rarely clear cut good and evil characters. One does wish the actors were better: Frederick Stafford is charming and suave but is not in the same breath as Hitchcock’s standard leading men, Karin Dor carries some weight, but again pales in skill to some Hitchcock’s more famous leading ladies. It still ends up being a decently paced espionage thriller. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film]
29. **Alice’s Restaurant:** Co-written and directed by Arthur Penn (*Bonnie and Clyde*), based on Arlo Guthrie’s song of the same name. Arlo stars as himself, and a few people also star as themselves such as Officer Obe and the Blind Judge. The film doesn’t fully embrace the anti-Vietnam stance of the song; outside of a black man having lost his arm in the war (which is a good minor plot

element). The plot contains a few other liberal ideas and items from the hippie movement: smoking, swinging/free-love, and an interracial couple (Arlo with an asian girl). Yet the adaptation does not exactly figure out what it wants to be about: focusing on Alice and Bill's relationship, a newly-created heroin-addict character, or Arlo's life. With an hour-and-fifty-minute runtime most of these side plots are not needed, and the film has at least five different natural endings. The best parts are almost always related to the song itself. Watch the film due to its relation to one of the great American protest songs, but realize it could have been much better. [Oscars – Best Director Nominee]

Tier 5: Well-Made, but Lacking the Special Sauce

28. **Take the Money and Run:** A early mockumentary written, directed, and starring Woody Allen, in his first real directorial effort. Too often the film seems to be a collections of sketches that are weakly connected, rather than a coherent narrative. Some of the bits are a lot better than others, but even the good ones often go on a bit too long (the stick-up note possibly being the worst offender). Allen needs to (and does) learn that less is more. The pieces are there that will be compose the good (and the bad) of Allen's future classics. It is still worth watching to she Allen style develop, but the film has flaws and those flaws are those of a first-time director. [Woody Allen]
27. **I am Sartana, Your Angel of Death (Sono Sartana, il vostro becchino):** The second film in the *Sartana* franchise, with Gianni Garko returning as the titular bounty hunter (he is much better in this franchise than his other Spaghetti Westerns as Sartana has a charismatic flair to him that Garko is able to get across instead of the usual stone-faced bounty hunters). Julian Carnimeo (*Find a Place to Die*) is now the director though. Klaus Kinski (*The Great Silence*) is great in a supporting role of a rival bounty hunter who is a gambling addict; his stagecoach sequence is great. The film once again leans into the outlandish killings that make the genre fun; the multiple knife-throwing deaths are enjoyable. [Spaghetti Western]
26. **Sabata (Ehi amico... c'è Sabata. Hai chiuso!):** Lee Van Cleef (*The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly* and *Death Rides a Horse*) is one of the great Spaghetti Western actors of all-time. He always brings both a charm and mischievousness to his characters which allow them to move being lovable and evil. The mixture works perfectly here as he plays a bounty hunter out to blackmail the local land-owners (who did stage an elaborate bank robbery). William Berger (*No Room To Die*) is good as the semi-comedic and aloof Banjo and is a nice foil to Cleef's more serious titular character. Director Gianfranco Parolini (*If You Meet Sartana Pray for Your Death*) does a nice job directing with some nicely framed shots (the raid on the mansion, and the dueling room being the best). The plot allows for multiple interesting kills (such as a gun in a bag, and in the banjo). Even still the film primarily works because Lee Van Cleef is that good. [Spaghetti Western]
25. **The Specialists (Gli specialisti):** The third film in Sergio Corbucci's (*Django* and *The Great Silence*) 'mud-and-blood' trilogy, and it is the weakest of the three. It still features Corbucci's great landscape shots and some of them are excellently framed with mountains int he background. The film also makes great use of shadow and light; it has the hallmarks of Corbucci's visual style. The side plot involving hippies distracts from the film (Corbucci included it because he hated hippies). Johnny Hallyday, a French singer, is surprising good in the leading role. The film also lacks the grit of Corbucci's better earlier films. For being a 'mud' film there isn't much of it. Yet, Corbucci is still the second-best Spaghetti Western director, and it isn't even close. [Spaghetti Western]
24. **On Her Majesty's Secret Service:** A few years back, I watched every *Bond* film. *OHMSS* was easily the best non-Craig film. Upon rewatch it still holds up. Part of what makes this a top-three *Bond* film is that it eschews all the bad 'tenants' of the franchise: Bond does not sleep with (assault) multiple women, there are no crazy gadgets, the cars are functional. It easy to see why contemporary (male) critics disliked the film—it didn't provide the cocksure Bond that Connery created. Instead

the film created the first Bond that was a developed character, and used the character to drive some of the plot (it still is a spy thriller after all). The direction is rather good, partially thanks to an editor directing the film. The actions sequences are rather good: the car race, the skiing sequences (especially the avalanche), and the bobsled. The ending of the film is possibly the best in the franchise. It is also two-hours-and-twenty-minutes, yet never drags. [*Bond Franchise*]

23. **Me, Natalie:** In many ways the film is a standard ‘ugly-ducking’ coming-of-age film. And it follows the subgenre’s conventions almost too a T (complete with voice-overs). Yet, Patty Duke (*Valley of Dolls*) is too good as the titular Natalie to ignore. She gives the character such emotional depth that as a viewer you can’t help but be invested in her life. The sets and costumes are all nice and a glimpse into the late-60s. The supporting cast is shocking good: Martin Balsam (*Hombre*), Nancy Marchand (*The Sopranos*), and Al Pacino (in his film debut). [Gold Globes – Best Actress Comedy/Musical]

22. **Sweet Charity:** There are a few musicals on the list, and this is the best of them almost entirely due to Bob Fosse (in his film directorial debut—he directed the stage version). Although the songs themselves aren’t that memorable (sans maybe ‘Big Spender’), the dance sequences are amazing and reveal how stifled and dated the other musicals on the list are. The celebrity nightclub dance sequence is amazing; Suzanne Charny was the lead dancer and was breathtaking. Throw in costumes by Edith Head, the numbers really pop (see the dress Charny wears). Shirley MacLaine (*Woman Times Seven*) is rather good and brings the proper amount of both charm and whimsy to the titular role (I never saw the original stage production, so I am unable to comment how it related to Gwen Verdon’s performance). Oh, and Sammy Davis Jr shows up for a single number and nearly steals the show. Fosse’s direction is a bit all over the place. He seems to have some issues with editing (an awkward zooming/fading in-and-out nearly ruins the movie in the first few minutes) and transitions. But as the film goes along he does get better. It is easy to see Bob Fosse was on his way to cinematic greatness. [Oscars – Best Costumes Nominee]

21. **The Learning Tree:** Written, directed, and composed by Gordon Parks, the film is perhaps more valuable for its historical importance than its overall quality as a film. It is one of the first major studio directed by a Black director (and Parks hired multiple Black behind-the-camera workers). The film itself is a little on-the-nose about racism (when looking at it thru modern eyes). The script is a tad iffy as the film is more slice-of-life than a coherent plot; there are multiple callbacks which are great. It is the plot that meanders and jumps around semi-haphazardly. Yet, nothing like this film was being made. Real depictions of everyday life for Black children. Although set in the 1920s, it could easily be set in 1969. The realistic depiction of lives usually overlooked, elevate the film and allow it to rank here. [Gordon Parks]

20. **Downhill Racer:** As Ebert put it, “a sports movie that isn’t about sports.” The film excels as it does not tell the audience much about the finer points of downhill skiing, but rather allows the audience to naturally pick up the important ideas over the course of the film. Most of the skiing shots look amazing (and are even more impressive than the ones feature in *OHMSS*). Michael Ritchie does a good job in his directorial debut. The true star is Robert Redford (*Barefoot in the Park*), but that is true of almost every film Redford is in. Redford gives the new hot-shot skier the silent charm and arrogance needed, while also giving the character enough vulnerability. Gene Hackman is also good, but his role of the team’s coach doesn’t give him as much room to shine. [WGA – Best Drama Nominee]

19. **Putney Swope:** Written and directed by Robert Downey (Sr.), who also overdubbed the voice of the titular Putney, the film is a nice satire of advertising, corporate culture, and race (the election of Swope as Chairman and the white worker asking for the raise are two of the best). The black-and-white cinematography often looks great (the final shot in particular is gorgeous); the only color sequences are the absurdist ads made by the company in the film. The opening sequence of the initial

board meeting is an absurdist comedic masterpiece. The jokes continue as the film goes on, but the lack of a real plot does bog the film down in the final as it starts to run out of energy. Despite the flaws, the film is still one of the better counter-culture (and even an early blaxploitation?) films. [Well-reviewed Comedy]

18. **Castle Keep:** A surrealist World War II film, that one wishes leaned into its surrealist elements even more (the anachronistic elements were good: the WV Beetle, and laddered fire truck). The plot attempts to provide a sense of repetition, but does not fully lean into the time-loop idea. The sexual themes are good, but could have been developed better. The art-vs-war theme is too heavy-handed, but appreciated; it does help with the repetition idea as similar ideas are portrayed with different artistic styles. The film is a unique attempt at a War Film, and had it leaned into the bizarre a bit more it would rank even higher. [Sydney Pollack]
17. **Where Eagles Dare:** The film is carried by a solid performance from Richard Burton (*Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*) (and who is honestly too good for it—allegedly he wanted to impress Lix Taylor's kids by being in a movie that wasn't a serious drama). Clint Eastwood brings his standard Clint Eastwood persona. The two work well together and carry the film through the various twists and turns (which there are a few too many). The aerial photography during the opening credits is great, and most everything involving the cable car is also excellent. The low points are when the film cuts from on-location snowscapes to sound stages with rear-projection or front-projection (the miniatures look decent but are still a tad jarring). The stunts are good and Yakima Canutt (*Branded a Bandit*) apparently directed some of the action sequences. The film is a solid entry in the more-crowded-than-you-think WW2 Nazis-bad get-in-get-out genre. [Burton and Eastwood]
16. **Machine Gun McCain:** A prelude to *The Godfather*. This film is not as good as *The Godfather*, but you can see the seeds: Italian mafia members, played by actual Italians, running casinos in Vegas. The drug dealing is only implied. Yet, it is still far more realistic than most crime films being made. John Cassavetes is the lead, and is as solid as always. The film needed to explore his character's romance more as that becomes a driving force behind the second half of the film. The issue is the film exists in this era where films can be made about bad guys, but the films rarely get gritty enough to be realistic. Watch so you can see the seeds being sown. [John Cassavetes]
15. **Bob & Alice & Ted & Carol:** The primary issue with the film is that it was dated the day it came out. It wanted to engage in counterculture swinging/open-marriages but within the confines of respectable society. It wanted to be daring, but often reverts back to more traditional values. With that out of the way, the film still excels as all four of the title characters are great. Natalie Wood (*This Property Is Condemned*) is probably the best (and somehow the one without nominations), as she captures the innocence of swinging; initially reluctant but quickly accepting; her admitting of an affair is both loving and nonchalant. Robert Culp might be the worst of the bunch, he also had to match Natalie Wood. Elliott Gould (*The Night They Raided Minsky's*, *being married to Barbra Streisand*) is good. Dylan Cannon (*being married to Cary Grant*) is also good. With a less-dated plot, and slight upgrades to the non-Wood actors, the film could move up a tier. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee]

Tier 4: Solid Forgotten Films and Under-the-Radar Classics

14. **Cemetery Without Crosses (Cimitero senza croci):** A French production of a spaghetti western, and it is one of the more artistic ventures. The film has little dialogue; emotion and characterization is done through the cinematography, the score, and the looks the characters give each other. In a genre that is often over the top, this film is stripped to the bare bones; the viewer needs to pay attention as plot elements are subtle (even if revenge is almost always the motivating factor). Robert Hossein writes, directs, and stars; he is responsible for creating a singular artistic vision. The

film even starts in black and white with a horse chase, the eventually fades to color and an eventual hanging with sets of the events of the film (we eventually learn said hanging was already set in motion because of the characters relations). A shot of a burning homestead is amazing. The ghost town looks great, and the scenery is almost always dusty. It is a beautiful and gritty entry in the genre. [Spaghetti Western]

13. **The Sterile Cuckoo:** Liza Minnelli (*Charlie Bubbles*) is amazing, and not only carries the film, but is the reason it ranks here. Her performance is elevated by the direction of Alan J. Pakula (in his directorial debut), as he allows the camera to linger on Minnelli; the bus, the phone call in the closet, and a few other long takes that allow Minnelli to fill the screen, capture and then hold the audience's attention. The film cannot rank any higher as the co-lead, Wendell Burton looks the part but that is all he brings. He looks like a lost nerdy boy, but he can not act, let alone match Minnelli. The film also a tad too long, but it does veer from the source novel, and that probably causes the dragging in the second half. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee]
12. **Model Shop:** The American debut of French New Wave director Jacques Demy (who's French films I have not seen). The film is set in Log Angeles, and features many shots of the lead driving his (soon-to-be-repossessed) car around the city (all of which are lovely and helps to encapsulate the feel of LA; yes I might be a bit biased). The film is one of the first to have the Vietnam War as a major plot point; the lead (in addition to having his car about to be repossessed) might have his draft number called any day. The film captures the anxiety and (seemingly) lack of ambition of twenty-somethings rather well (it is no *The Graduate*). The biggest issue with the film is that Gary Lockwood (*2001: A Space Odyssey*) is not that good in the lead, he needs to be more charismatic, as he at least gets the quiet stoic part down (he is also 31 playing a 26 year old). Perhaps worst of all Harrison Ford(!) was the director's choice but the studio vetoed the young unknown actor (*American Graffiti* is still four years away). One can only imagine how much better the final product would have been with Ford in the lead. The film is a quality drama about loneliness and being adrift, with quality direction. Oh, and Anouk Aimée is also rather good. [Partial Inspiration for *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood*]
11. **Cactus Flower:** In some ways the film is a more light-hearted and comedic *Bob & Alice & Ted & Carol*, and because of the lighter mood, it is easier to forgive the flaws of wanting to be about the Swinging 60s, while still being old-fashioned. Where *Flower* succeeds is that the script is funnier, with frequent laughs. Although Natalie Wood is the best across the two films, the four next best actors are all in *Cactus Flower*, partially out of sheer star power. Walter Matthau is one of the greatest (comedic) actors of all time and although it is a tad difficult to see him as an older swinging dentist, he somehow comes close enough to pulling it off because he is Walter Matthau after all. Indrig Bergman is amazing as the old-maid-receptionist-turned-gal-on-the-town (you can already guess where this one is going!), but again all is forgiven as Bergman is one of the few women in contention for greatest actress of all time; she is that good. Goldie Hawn puts in a breakthru performance and might even outperform the two stars. Her slight little reactions are great and she gives the character the right balance of sex appeal and innocence (even if Hawn benefited from some slight category fraud by being listed as a Supporting Actress; she was a co-lead). Quincy Jones even adds some great music (frequently rearranging popular songs to be the right amount of funky), and in a bit of irony Jones also did the music for *Bob & Alice & Ted & Carol*. Despite being a tad old-fashioned, a funny script with an all-time cast still produces movie magic. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actress]
10. **Goodbye, Columbus:** A film that feels like less-good remake of *The Graduate* and the first step on the way to the rom-com atom-splitting that was *Annie Hall*. The film has multiple good jokes and some social commentary. Most of the commentary revolves around birth control and frank discussions of it. Though the film touches a little bit on race (a black kid in the library, but that is a side plot that never pays off), Vietnam (the male lead mentions he was in the Army, but it is left at that), and

class (which is brought up a few too many times). The entire wedding sequence results in the film losing most of its steam near the end. The film is primarily held together as both leads of Richard Benjamin and Ali MacGraw are rather good (but neither great; McGraw's final scene could have been much better). Jack Klugman (who would go on to star in TV's *The Odd Couple* is good in a supporting role. Overall the film is good, but one wishes it was slightly better. [Oscars – Best Adapted Screenplay Nominee]

9. **Medium Cool:** Probably the film on the list I need to rewatch the most. It is set in the lead-up and during the 1968 Democratic Convention in Chicago, which is probably not the best thing to be watching a few days before the 2024 Presidential Election (this will be a theme of the list). Part of what makes the film great is that it is a pseudo-documentary; the shots from the convention and protests are from the convention and protests. Therefore, many of the actors are non-actors and describing why they are at the convention (the set up works as the main character is a journalist). The pseudo-documentary feel is often a turn off for me, as I dislike that style. Haskell Wexler was the director and cinematography (he had done the cinematography on such films as *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*, and the film often looks great; starting with a beautiful motorcycle sequence during the opening credits. [DGA – Outstanding Achievement Nominee]
8. **They Shoot Horses, Don't They:** The film is possibly best-known for having a record nine Oscar nominations, without receiving a Best Picture Nomination. In many ways, that is the perfect tweet-length review of the film as well. Sydney Pollack (*This Property Is Condemned*) does a good job directing, especially as the film essentially take place in one location (with side offices, sleeping quarters, and showers). The sets, costumes, and make up are rather good. They capture the feel of the Depression and the slow decay of the characters. Though perhaps the best part of the film are the flash-forwards which allude to the ending. Gig Young won Best Supporting Actor, but he was good not great. Susannah York (*The Battle of Britain*) was nominated for Supporting Actress and was better than him. The real star of the film is Jane Fonda (*Barefoot in the Park*), as she carries the film and it might be the first film she is able to flex her acting chops. Sadly her co-star, Michael Sarrazin, was not able to match her. The film could have also focused on some of the supporting characters—Bruce Dern played one! The film is good, with good commentary on human suffering and poverty. Yet, one wishes it was better. But there isn't an easy item to point to for easy improvement; again, it is fitting the film didn't receive a Best Picture Nomination. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee]
7. **The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie:** Maggie Smith (*Hot Millions*) won the Oscar for Best Actress and she carries the film (she deserved the nomination, though the performance was not the clear-cut best of the year). Pamela Franklin (*Our Mother's House*) is the real star of the film and provides the necessary foil to Smith's titular Brodie (she received a BAFTA and NBR nomination—winning at the National Board of Review). The writing itself is a little heavy-handed; the foreshadowing of Brodie's love of dictators gets slopped on (with little reason given for her support; one can assume it has to deal with desiring strong men), the frequency with which 'my prime' is uttered is twenty times too many. Likewise, the 'crème de la crème' is repeated too often. These do veer into grating territory, and could easily drop the film a tier. Except once, again, Smith and Franklin are so good the errors can be forgiven. Even if some more character development could have shored-up the film. [Oscars – Best Actress Winner]
6. **Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid:** The film far too often feels like a worse remake of *Bonnie and Clyde*, especially as the film ingrains the idea that these lead characters can not go straight; robbing banks is what they are born to do. The film is also in need of a proper restoration, as the existing bluray print needs touching up in a lot of places. Yet all of that is forgiven for a few key reasons: the opening (almost uncut) sepia-tinted sequence is a masterclass in how to start a film. The (also sepia-tinted) traveling sequence as Butch and Sundance feel to Boliva is a masterclass in editing.

The final shot (also, eventually, sepia-tinted) is iconic and gorgeous. (George Roy Hill (*Thoroughly Modern Millie*) does a great job directing). ‘Raindrops Keep Falling on My Head’ is one of the best original songs in film history, and used to great effect. Yet the best part is still Paul Newman and Robert Redford; pairing two of the most effortlessly-charming actors of all-time produces great results. Those two are so good, that most all other sins are forgiven; fight for control of the gang, jumping off the cliff, all the broken-spanish bank robberies, the stealing back the payroll, the final scene. Those two are that good together and have permanently set the bar for male chemistry. Newman and Redford may not be in the inner-circle of actors when it comes to talent, but they are inner-circle actors when it comes to charm and charisma. They work perfectly together such that the sins are forgiven. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]

Tier 3: Must Watch

5. **The Rain People:** An American road-trip film written and directed by Francis Ford Coppola (*You’re a Big Boy Now*). The star of the film is Shirley Knight (*The Group, Petulia*). Her phonebooth scene is superb. James Caan (*El Dorado*) is also rather good (and does not go full retard). The interaction of their two characters, both aimless and adrift, allow for great drama as Caan is happy to be on the ride of life, while her character is in need of finding herself. Robert Duval (*The Chase*) shows up and really breaks thru. He adds a third complicated character to the mix. The characters are developed and complicated humans who drive the plot. The ending itself is a bit of a miss. Coppola shows again that he was a talent to watch as a director; the opening credits, the Simon-says mirror shot, the flashlight-lit monologue, and the flashbacks are all excellently done. [Francis Ford Coppola]
4. **The Wild Bunch:** Co-written and Directed by Sam Peckinpah, it is the first truly ‘violent’ American film; what started with Spaghetti Westerns and made *Bonnie and Clyde* great is finally put together here in a complete film and it starts from the beginning; an bloody and well-shot ambush of the titular Wild Bunch in the middle of robbing a bank (that includes lots of friendly-fire deaths from the posse)—it also starts with an interesting set up with the opening credits. The film is also one of the few American films where the allegory of the (failing) Vietnam War is front and center. The posse is composed of incompetent low-lives and a former outlaw who is leading the posse in return for his freedom, and some even shoot the actual Army recruits. The Army is even more incompetent and composed on only green recruits. Continuing with the revolution of New American Cinema, the ‘bad guys’ in the Wild Bunch are actually the most compassionate and caring with clear sets of morals. The train robbery sequence is decent, but there have been a few better ones in recent years. The slow-motion shots do not do it for me, though a few of the wilderness shots are nice. The final battle sequence is bloody and throws convention out the window, and is a main reason the film is in this tier and not a lower one. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee]
3. **Z:** A film that might be better than this ranking. However watching a film about suppression under a soon-to-be fascist government on October 23rd 2024 wasn’t the best choice. The film even has a well-meaning prosecutor who wants to solve the crime, not merely follow the government’s narrative. What the film nails is how fascist governments are interested in plausible deniability of their actions; the counter-protesters are just a group of regular citizens (funded and aided by government officials; again no way this relates to Jan 6 and the looming election). It is one of the best films on fascist rule, it is a great legal thriller, and wonderfully edited. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]

Tier 2: Captain America

2. **Easy Rider:** When I first saw the film in 2009, I hated it. I was wrong and owe it a massive apology. The film sums up the angsty themes that have been boiling up in the films of the last few years. And not only does it incorporate those themes it even offers a critical view of the themes. Unlike

many teen films, the film makes crystal clear who ‘The Man’ is: Racist White Men. The first group met on the road trip is an interracial couple (white man and an indigenous woman) with lots of kids, who live peacefully on their own not harming a soul (a beautiful composed shot of the farmer changing a horseshoe while they change a bike tire only helps to solidify their solidarity in a cause). The next stop is a free-love commune, which serves as an excellent time capsule. Along the journey cinematography László Kovács (*Targets*) captures the beauty of the American West, overlaid with a moving soundtrack of modern songs (following *The Graduate* and *Who’s That Knocking At My Door*, but in this film the connection between soundtrack and characterization is perfected). Jack Nicholson (*Hells Angels on Wheels*) is in his breakout role, and deservedly so—his character and his realization of the character is central to the film. Nicholson plays an alcoholic ACLU lawyer, but because his vice is the socially acceptable alcohol, and his father is a respected man in the community he receives preferential treatment from the police. Again, the film acutely pins that ‘The Man’ is a specific-type of White Man. The editing of the campfire scenes, the flash forward, and the acid trip incorporates French New Wave techniques and while many films had attempted to show an acid trip, this is one of the first that perfected it. It is astonishingly rare that a film sums up the zeitgeist, establishes new standards of film-making, and still offers a reflective and critical view of said zeitgeist. Captain America might think he blew it, but Dennis Hopper and Peter Fonda certainly, did not. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee]

Tier 1: A Borderline All-Timer

1. **Midnight Cowboy:** Dustin Hoffman literally followed up *The Graduate* with *Midnight Cowboy*. Two all-time performances, and wildly different roles. Ratso is by most accounts a slimeball, but a script and Hoffman’s performance turn him in a developed and complex character (the shoe-shining scene is amazing). One wonders if Hoffman was up for Best Supporting Actor (it is debatable if he is a co-lead or supporting) he would won his first Oscar instead of having to wait until 1980. Jon Voight is a breakout star and his combination of charm and naivete are essential to advance the film. The costume design is amazing as the clothes get grimy-er as the plot progress. The flashbacks (memories? hallucinations?; the film does a great job of never implying which events actually happened) are all amazingly shot and are the prefect example of show-not-tell character development. The showing allows for multiple interpretations of why Voight’s character wants to leave Texas to be a gigolo for rich older ladies, detailing them here risks spoilers but repressed homosexuality sure might be one of them. Although ‘Everybody’s Talkin at Me’ is not an original song, it is still great, and the harmonica score built around it adds to the loneliness of the two characters. John Schlesinger (*Far From the Maddening Crowd*) is excellent at the helm as director, his flashbacks, use of color, and others all help to wrap the film together, ensuring it isn’t a good film with two great performances, it is a great film with two great performances about two hurt and abandoned people who forge a beautiful and unlikely friendship. [Oscars – Best Picture]